

Copenhagen Primer

■ **GLOBAL WARMING** is caused by rise in levels of carbon dioxide in the atmosphere that acts as blanket to contain radiated heat and raises overall global temperatures to dangerous levels, leading to melting glaciers, rise in sea levels, freaky weather and changing climate patterns.

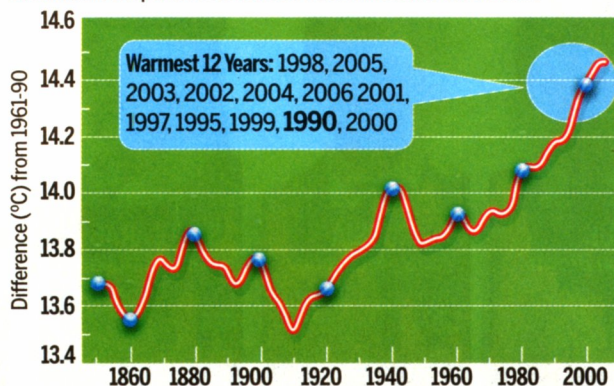
■ **KYOTO PROTOCOL** requires industrialised countries to bring down their emissions to 5 per cent less than the 1990 levels and assist the developing countries in avoiding the negative effects of climate change. Legally binding targets for 37 industrialised countries and the European community (called the Annex 1 countries) for reducing greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions were set. Adopted in Kyoto, Japan, in 1997, it entered into force in 2005. US has not ratified the Protocol.

■ **IPCC** or the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change in 2007 reported that the average global temperature could rise 4.5°C by 2050, resulting in debilitating climate changes.

■ **COPENHAGEN** climate change conference is being held to fix enhanced emission reduction targets for rich countries during the second commitment period of the Kyoto Protocol, which starts from 2012. Most countries have not fulfilled even their first commitment period targets.

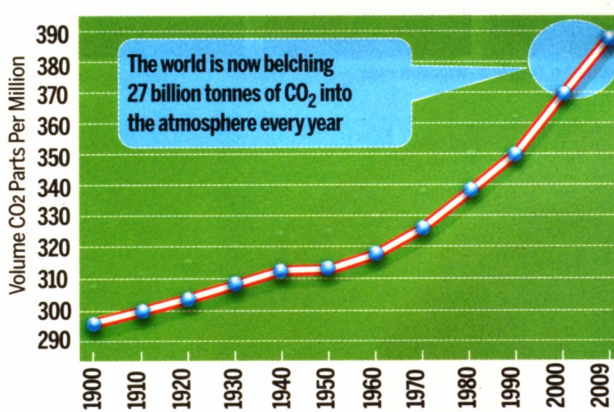
Mercury Rising

Global mean temperatures have risen fastest in the last two decades



Gassed Out

CO₂ levels have reached dangerous proportions in the atmosphere



PRASHANT CHAUDHARY/www.indiatodayimages.com

Gordon Brown, the British premier. Even that figure has receded and currently the developed nations are looking at \$40 billion and that too directed only towards the least developed countries. The industrialised countries were also to impart clean technology that would have helped developing countries reduce their emission levels. However, these countries have raised issues about Intellectual Property Rights and now talk of only information sharing rather than knowhow.

So why is America, which has a per capita GHG emission close to 18 times more than an average Indian, refusing to comply despite having a President who has pledged to change the way the US did business? The quick answer: it just has too many big lobbies that are willing to spend over \$300 million a year to ensure that the status quo remains. This includes the coal lobby that has a say in 22 of the 50 states, the oil lobby that George Bush was close too, apart from the automobile and highway lobbies. So, even if Obama had pledged to cut GHG emissions by 17 per cent by 2020, he will face great difficulty having it ratified

in the Senate. Not surprising when you think that the Kyoto Protocol which was negotiated by Al Gore, the then US Vice President, was rejected 95-0 by the Senate—resulting in one of the many inconvenient truths about America.

The US' main argument is that Kyoto doesn't bring into its ambit two of the world's largest emitters of GHGs, China and India. China is an anomaly as it has now overtaken the US as the largest emitter of GHGs and given its frenetic economic growth is fast moving out of the developing country orbit. Yet China knows that it would need at least a decade or so before it can stabilise its energy intensity or come up with green tech that could substantially reduce its emission levels without impacting growth. So till recently it had refused to take on even voluntary, non-binding cuts. Only last month did President Hu Jintao announce that China would cut its carbon emission intensity by 40 per cent. That, of course, is not comparable to what developed countries are expected to do, which is cut their overall emission levels while carbon intensity is linked to energy used to produce every dollar of the GDP. In real terms, it will not see a drop